

THE RIVER DON'T WEEP

[Intro: 78 BPM, dark West Coast drill, eerie two-note bass motif, distant traffic and rain, sparse drums, close-mic male vocal, conversational with a sly grin]

there's a fool on Turk Street with a mouth full of shit

(yeah)

selling chains with a smile like they're diamonds and shit

(full of it)

but listen real close

'cause the river got something to say

[Verse 1: bouncy anapestic pocket, tight boom-bap drums, clipped consonants, playful street-preacher cadence]

he'll sell you the water like it's liquid gold, damn

(loose)

preach you the truth while he's counting his cash

(count it)

say, "baby, don't hold on, just trust in the plan"

(trust)

while he's holding your money inside of his hand

(his hand)

got a mouth full of silk and a goddamn snake tongue

(slick)

every sweet little sermon got another hook hung

(hooked)

"keep your hands clean, don't carry no weight"

(no weight)

then he takes every dollar you made from the late

(every one)

he'll dress up the hustle like a lesson in trust

(call it trust)

"keep your hands clean, baby, bring it to us"

(bring it)

put her out on the block where the streetlights blink

(right there)

tell her what to say, tell her what to think

(say it)

count every dollar before she can breathe

(count it)

then preach about freedom like he's handing her keys

(keys?)

that's the joke in the sermon he don't wanna see

(don't see)

you can't teach somebody freedom

then charge them to leave

[Pre-Hook: drums pull back, bass pulses, vocal becomes hypnotic, whispers stack around final phrase]
third time hearing it
(same sermon)
fourth time seeing it
(same hand)
something in her finally said
(that ain't love)
that ain't freedom
(that ain't freedom)

[Hook: huge simple chant, hard kick and sub, memorable melody, main vocal dominant, backing voices reinforce only key phrases]
you said, "don't hold on"
(don't hold on)
so I let you go
(let you go)

you said, "don't hold on"
(don't hold on)
now watch me go

the river don't weep
(don't weep)
the river don't beg
(don't beg)

you can't put a leash on water
and expect it to stay wet
(keep moving)

[Verse 2: colder beat, more space, vocal loses smirk, realization turning into resolve]
by the fourth fuckin' sermon, something shifted in her
(something changed)
she stopped hearin' wisdom, started hearin' the chains
(chains)
looked down at the corner, then looked at his hand
(look at him)
watched him count up her money like he owned where she stand
(owned it)

she ain't cry for that punk, nah, fuck that
(no)
she ain't beg, she ain't plead, she just gathered her shit
(she moved)
he reached for the envelope, she pulled it away
(mine)
said, "you told me don't hold on to shit that I make"

[Beat Stop]

"so I'm not holding on to you."

[Silence]

then she turned from the block and walked off through the rain

(walk)

he hollered her name but she kept walking away

(keep walking)

he called her ungrateful, called her crazy, called her dumb

(let him talk)

but every step she took said,

"you don't own where I'm from"

[Hook: full drums, hook repeated exactly for memorability, backing voices wider]

you said, "don't hold on"

(don't hold on)

so I let you go

(let you go)

you said, "don't hold on"

(don't hold on)

now watch me go

the river don't weep

(don't weep)

the river don't beg

(don't beg)

you can't put a leash on water

and expect it to stay wet

(keep moving)

[Break: drums drop completely, rain and sub-bass, intimate spoken delivery]

that's the funny part

[Pause]

you spent all that time

teaching her how not to hold on

[Pause]

then got surprised

when she finally learned

[Whisper]

you

[Long Silence]

[Bridge: beatless, extremely dry vocal, then gradual instrumental rebuild]

he called it loyalty
but loyalty don't need a threat

he called it love
but love don't collect a debt

he called it protection
but protection ain't possession

and every time he said
"you need me"

what he meant was

"don't leave me"

[Low Whisper]
there's a difference

[Verse 3: beat returns with stronger bounce, vocal confident and liberated, drums progressively open]

now he's back on the corner with the same old grin

(same old grin)

same sermon, same hustle, same bullshit again

(same shit)

but the girl that he owned in the story he tells

(ain't there)

is somewhere learning the sound of herself

and maybe she ain't got a mansion

(maybe not)

maybe she ain't got a dollar tonight

(not yet)

but nobody's counting her breath

nobody's telling her where she can walk

or when she can stop

that's freedom

(freedom)

not having everything

just knowing

what nobody gets to take

[Final Hook: biggest section, layered chant, main vocal front and center, simple melody, final line extended]

you said, "don't hold on"

(don't hold on)
so I let you go
(let you go)

you said, "don't hold on"
(don't hold on)
now watch me go

the river don't weep
(don't weep)
the river don't beg
(don't beg)

you can't put a leash on water
and expect it to stay wet
(keep moving)

you said, "don't hold on"
(don't hold on)

so I let you go

[Outro: drums disappear one element at a time, vocal nearly whispered, distant ghost voices]
don't hold on
(don't hold on)

keep moving

(keep moving)

the river don't weep

it just keeps moving

[Final isolated whisper]
so move